

IV Personal Reflection

A quiet session of individual exercises: meet the commandments through your own online life before discussing anyone else's.

AUDIENCE

Adults and staff preparing to lead Digital Mensches: counselors, educators, parents, and community leaders. Also works well for older teens.

GROUP SIZE

Any size, including one. This program also works entirely alone: do segments 1 through 5 as personal reflection and skip the sharing.

ROOM

Anywhere people can write comfortably and quietly.

STAFFING

One facilitator to keep time and lead the sharing. For solo use, none.

Why This Session Exists

By the end, a participant should be able to name at least two Jewish values from the document and apply each to a real situation from their own online life, take a position on a dilemma and give a reason for it, and name one thing in the document they disagree with or find missing. In this format there is one additional aim: an adult who is preparing to lead should have had the conversation with themselves before asking teens to have it.

Two values reflected on honestly beats ten skimmed. The timings here are guidance, not requirements. Full objectives and enduring understandings are at the front of the Study Guide.

ADAPTING TO YOUR GROUP

If time gets short: protect the private writing time. Sharing can shrink to a single round of one sentence each, or disappear entirely, and the program still does its work.

With a staff team: say at the start that nothing written will be collected. The honesty of the reflection depends on it.

Materials

- ☐ Camper handouts or the full Ten Commandments document, one per person
- ☐ Paper or journals and pens, one per person

Timing

This program can be adapted based on time available.

Segment	45 min	60 min	90 min
1. Setup and framing	5	5	10
2. Self-assessment	10	10	15

3. A personal story	5	10	10
4. Your AI story	10	10	15
5. The value that speaks to you	5	5	10
6. Pair share	10	10	15
7. Group discussion	–	10	15
Total	45	60	90

Pick your column and follow it top to bottom; each column adds up on its own. Working alone? Do segments 1 through 5 and give the sharing time back to the writing.

Running the Session

1. Setup and Framing (5/5/10 min)

Hand out the commandments and writing materials. Name the premise: before we talk about what teens do online, we look honestly at what we do online. Everything written in this session is private; nothing is collected, and sharing later is always by choice.

SUGGESTED FRAMING

The Kotzker Rebbe was asked why the Torah commands us not to deceive others when everyone already knows deception is wrong. He answered that the harder commandment is hidden inside it: do not deceive yourself. This session is thirty quiet minutes of not deceiving ourselves about our own screens.

2. Self-Assessment (10/10/15 min)

Everyone reads through all ten commandments, then rates themselves on each one, from one ("this is a real struggle for me") to five ("I consistently live this value online"). Write the number next to each commandment, with a word or two of notes. There are no right answers, and nobody will see the page.

FIELD NOTE

The gap between the commandment people score lowest and the one they assumed they would score lowest is often the most interesting thing in the room. Invite people to notice, not to fix.

3. A Personal Story (5/10/10 min)

Think of a specific moment when you witnessed or experienced either the best or the worst of online behavior. Write a brief account, three to five sentences. Which of the Ten Commandments does your story connect to? How did the experience affect you?

4. Your AI Story (10/10/15 min)

Reflect in writing on your own relationship with AI tools. Have you used chatbots, writing assistants, or image generators? Did it raise ethical questions for you, about honesty, about effort, about where the content came from? If you have not used AI tools, what assumptions or concerns do you bring to the conversation?

SAY THIS OUT LOUD

Be honest. Many adults feel behind on this topic, and that is perfectly normal. The teens we serve do not need us to be experts; they need us to be honest companions who have done our own thinking.

5. The Value That Speaks to You (5/5/10 min)

Of the Jewish values paired with these commandments, which one resonates most deeply with you personally? Why? Has your relationship with this value changed in the digital age? Write a few sentences.

6. Pair Share (10/10/15 min)

In pairs, each person shares one thing from their writing, their choice of which. The listener's only job is to ask one curious follow-up question. Then switch. Nobody reads anyone's page.

7. Group Discussion (–/10/15 min)

Open with whichever of these fits your group:

Discussion Prompts

- What surprised you about your own self-assessment?
- Which commandment is hardest for the adults in this room, and is it the same one that is hardest for teens?
- What did writing your AI story clarify for you?
- How does doing this reflection change how you would lead it with teens?

Facilitation Notes

- **Protect the quiet.** The writing segments are silent work. Resist the urge to fill the room with talk; the discomfort of quiet writing is where the honesty comes from.
- **Privacy is the engine.** Say more than once that nothing written will be collected or read. People are honest on paper in direct proportion to how safe the paper is.
- **Model it.** If you are leading staff, do the exercises yourself and share something real in the pair share. Vulnerability from the leader sets the ceiling for everyone else.
- **Use it as preparation.** This program is the recommended first step for any team about to run Digital Mensches with teens: adults lead the conversation better after they have had it with themselves.